resistance. As a result, the SSA was formed by the amalgamation of the Shan National United Front and Shan State Independence Army in 1964 (Chao Tzang Yawnghwe 2010; Sai Aung Tun 2009; Yawnghwe 2013). Yet, it is too simplistic to brand the SSA as anti-state. In fact, the state and the SSA had a common interest in defeating the CPB (Lintner 1999; Lintner and Black 2009).

Despite official denouncement of the cultivation of opium, all armed groups in Shan State took advantage of the easy rent-seeking opportunities, which put the SSA, PNO, and PNLO into direct confrontation. In 1989, after the SSA signed a ceasefire agreement with SLORC, a breakaway group led by drug lord Khun Sa formed the Mong Tai Army and the political unit known as the Shan State Restoration Council to protect their opium interests, and continued fighting against the state. Khun Sa eventually surrendered in 1996, but Lieutenant General Sao Yawd Serk led another breakaway group to establish the SSA-S and formed the RCSS as its political wing. The RCSS/SSA-S signed its ceasefire agreement with the government in 2011. As a result of overlapping interests in the smuggling trade routes between southern Shan State and Thailand, conflicts between the RCSS/SSA-S and PNLO constantly flare up, with the central government playing a role in flaming the hostilities between the two.

The 2008 Constitution turned a new chapter in Myanmar's political history, as it paved the way for the first general election in twenty years, in 2010. The election reactivated political party activities, as ethnic Shan parties and national parties began to contest one another to represent the ethnic minorities in the southern Shan State. Among them was the Shan Nationalities League for Democracy (SNLD), which was founded in 1989, around the same time as the NLD. The party boycotted the 2010 election, but registered again as a political party to contest the 2015 election. In its stead, the Shan Nationalities Democratic Party (SNDP) was formed in 2010 to represent Shan in the election that year. Also known as the White Tiger Party or the Tiger Head, the party was considered pro-regime.

Despite reports the SNLD would cooperate with the SNDP in the 2015 election, both parties ran their own election campaigns and contested seats in the same constituencies.[5] The SNDP lost all upper and lower house seats in 2015, whereas the SNLD won three seats in the Amyotha Hluttaw, twelve seats in the Pyithu Hluttaw, and twenty-five seats in the State and Regional Hluttaws.[6] While the SNLD does not have any direct conflict of interest with the Pa-O, the party is sympathetic to Shan armed groups and enjoys a good relationship with the RCSS/SSA-S.